# Found sound

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A review with excerpts from 3 sound features broadcast by *The Listening Room,* the ABC's Radiophonic program that goes to air on Monday nights.

The pieces are:

*Resava Cave*…….by Arenje Jovanovic
Stone as a musical instrument. A composition using percussive sounds from rock formations in a cave beneath a Monastery in Croatia.

*Wake for Tom*……. by Jim McKee and Barney Jones
Speech as music and poetry. Stories from homeless people on the street.

*Currawong*……. by Moya Henderson
Found sounds at the edge of the forest expressed in quasi-classical musical form.

## Introduction

I am completing a PhD thesis on the subject of The Listening Room, a program on ABC Classic FM Radio devoted to sound art; I am writing about its history, the part it has played in the development of sound art in Australia and in the development of Australian composers, and the place it occupies within the world culture of sound art broadcasting. Every week, for about 11 months of the year since 1988, The Listening Room program has gone to air on ABC Classic FM; I have selected the first 10 years of its existence for detailed study.

I am literally working within The Listening Room in that I have a working space, access to files and scripts, archival and current tapes and CDs, people to talk to, library, data base and so on.

Going back to the 1970s and 80s, as portable sound recording equipment became smaller and lighter, and improved in quality, so more sounds were found. Some members of The Listening Room team still speak of the thrill they experienced when first hearing the recorded sounds of tiny insects chirping and clicking. All pretty old hat now, but significant in the history of sound art. So it was that sounds that previously had not been available for use, you might say, as instruments became available as technology advanced.

In the course of my work at the ABC I have listened to many compositions using found sound and I have selected three of these which I have found particularly appealing. I find them engaging pieces, technically of broadcast quality and possessing a strong aesthetic content. Each is an example of a different kind of found sound. Each is an example of the skill of composition. Here are excerpts from them.

## *Resava Cave*

Broadcast date: 29/2/93
Composer: Arenje Jovanovic
Producer: Arenje Jovanovic
Duration: 14 minutes.

Sounds for *Resava Cave* were recorded in a cave of that name in Serbia by Arenje Jovanovic and a group of his students and 2 musicians. It won the Prix Italia at the International Radio Festival of 1989, an award that Jovanovic had then won several times. It has been put to air by The Listening Room 3 times during the 10 year period under my review.

The Cave is some 15 m. into the cliff face below a 15th Century Monastery just outside Belgrade and contains the stalagmites and stalactites that form the instruments played by Jovanovic and his students. Using sticks and stones and hands the players generate a great variety of sounds, sounds that in most cases express their character across a range of frequencies, depending on how and where the formations are struck. Selected and edited by the composer, and combined with the human voice, these are the components of the composition. In his introduction to the feature Jovanovic describes it as one of the most important experiments in the development of his composition of sound art.

The various 'instruments' used produce tones of great beauty and character. The sound that is created when a stalagmite or stalactite in the cave is struck is a truly musical note with a clear fundamental, and harmonics that express the nature of the material. That the material is immediately recognizable as stone is, I believe, a significant contributer to the aura of *Resava Cave*. The sound conveys the essence of stone, its noble characteristics of, for example, strength, stability, endurance and timelessness. The sound it makes when struck becomes a musical metaphor for these qualities, and of course others. This must be one of the advantages of working with sounds from the natural world, as in the minds of listeners there already exists a perception of characteristics associated with a particular sound.

In structure the piece contains elements of conventional musical form, with crescendo and de-crescendo, approach and retire, movements across the soundscape, climaxes and silences. Sometimes the quiet episodes are filled with the soft throbbing of insects or sounds like the beating of a heart or the gentle breathing of sleep. At times the haunting voices of women float through the air, contrasting with the percussive sounds of sticks hitting solid resonant rock. As the piece progresses the simple lines of the beginning change slowly to complex layering and increasing sound levels, rising to a plateau. Then simplicity returns and the music comes to a placid ending. It is easy to imagine how the effect of *Resava Cave* comes from the improvised generation of sounds, by candlelight in an echoing cave many centuries old.

The significance of the feature I believe lies in the imaginative choice of a sound arena, and the beauty of the resulting composition; the choice of sounds and their arranging that bring to the imagination of the listener feelings of awe, a quality of history and immersion in the resonances of the cave.

## *Wake for Tom*

Date to air: 18/4/94
Producer: Jim McKee
Composers: Jim McKee and Barney Jones
Duration: 28 minutes

At the time of composition Jim McKee and Barney Jones together ran the business Earwax Productions in San Francisco where they made their living by creating sound material for commercial purposes, their customers mainly small independent media outlets. They were well paid for their work but mostly they had to deal with current matters, in the way of a cartoonist, and meet short deadlines. *Wake for Tom* was different; it was funded by a small grant, way below the usual hourly commercial rate, its composition

stretching over a period of about 12 months. Their subject matter was just outside the door, on the street, the homeless alcoholics in the Tenderloin district of San Francisco.

In 1993 Jones and McKee won an Oscar for their sound editing of Cuppola's film Dracula. They had also made in 1987 what they call an 'Audiograph' titled *Pop songs from the Tenderloin; Wake for Tom*; it was their second Audiograph and was an entry in the 1993 Berlin Prix Futura.

To find out more about the history of *Wake for Tom*, Listening Room Producer Robyn Ravlich talked with the composers by phone from Sydney and this conversation became part of the broadcast Introduction of the piece. The composers recount how, by edited conversations with men and women of the street people, the story of living and dying on the street and in particular the death of Tom, is told by the people themselves. Their voices are the only voices heard, set over a running theme of piano music, plus other conventional instruments from time to time.

With no payment attached to the outcome and no deadline for its completion, *Wake for Tom* developed within a lengthy time-frame, with McKee and Jones being able to consider the results of what they refer to as their own compositional research. Although the composers had no real idea of what would happen as they worked on the recorded material, they had the object of turning Interview into Theatre, of making music from spoken words. In the phone conversation with Ravlich one of the composers says: 'There is so much music in what people say, there are tunes and rhythms to be turned into music — you may as well be poetical, make it flow as music'. They go on to describe 'throwing the voice about to where the music is', and in another part of the conversation they talk about laying the music into the speech structure.

What the composers set about doing was to find, in the mass of recorded material, voices that expressed in both sound and meaning what they wanted to communicate, and 'throw' these into the music of the piano. 'Throwing' was helped significantly by the use of digital mixing technique, which was apparently new to them at the time and took the place of bringing analogue tape tracks together. It was quicker and more accurate; there was no 'that'll be good enough', it could all be done so as to satisfy exactly the composer's creative intent.

There are no actors, no interviewers, no narrators in this Feature; the story is told by the street people. Through their words their world is described in little musical poems, each one telling about some part of it; waking, sleeping, begging, dying. The poetry of words comes through in expressions such as:

> Spare a little change?
>
> Let's see, Howard died in August.
> Carol died in September.
> Steve died in November.
> We're waiting for December.
>
> You got someplace where you can store these ashes for a while?
>
> You can't panhandle here.
>
> Spare a little change
> So I can stay drunk and unemployed.
> A dime for a bottle of wine?
> At least I'm honest.

Melded with sounds of the piano, the story emerges as a musical event, its own rhythm and melody so subtle as to be unremarkable, but with a tempo and shape consistent with the story.

So written, in what they describe as a 'song structure', and through their choice of the words spoken, the composers believe that they may have helped reveal some kind of essence in the existence of these people. They believe that perhaps in an accidental way their work communicates with 'truth' or at least expresses with 'objectivity', the life of the street people. This goes a step further than the suggestion that found sounds go to make an interesting or engaging musical composition. The composers are suggesting that by adding their minds and skills to sounds that are part of a culture they reveal or communicate an essence or spirit of that culture not usually perceptible..they have been instrumental in discovering and imparting a truth.

## *Currawong*

Broadcast date:8/8/88
Composer: Moya Henderson
Duration: 22 minutes.
Commissioned by WDR (West German Radio) as a co-production with the ABC.

Australian composer Moya Henderson was commissioned by Klaus Schoning of West German Radio to write a piece for co-production with the Australian Broadcasting Corporation for broadcast by Schoning's Studio Akustische Kunst. Originally named *Currawong — a symphony of birds*, the sounds were recorded by Sound Engineer Phillip Ulman at Barrington Tops, a wilderness area a few hours drive north of Sydney, at dawn as the birds were feeding at the garbage containers of the local Guest House. Later, Ulman recorded the calls of Bellbirds and other varieties in nearby trees, thus presenting the composer with a range of bird song and environments from which to make her creative selection. Henderson writes that her 'job as composer was to highlight the drama and humour of these early morning feeding frenzies, and to enhance the listener's awareness of the extraordinary polyphony that fills the dawn skies over the Barrington Tops Guest House'.

Moya Henderson writes that broad symphonic form inspired the way in which the sounds were put together and this aspect was examined further by Sally Macarthur of the University of Western Sydney in her doctoral thesis. In advancing an argument supporting this statement Dr Macarthur refers to her aural analysis of the piece (there is no score) and derives from that four sound groups, viz Introduction, Exposition, Development and Recapitulation, each with its own internal elements capable of being identified in broad classical musical terminology, i.e. first subject, second subject and so on. Macarthur proposes that in selecting from the recorded material presented to her by the sound engineer, Henderson followed a path suggested by her training in Classical form. Another viewpoint on the matter of compositional structure is that in setting out to `highlight the drama and humour of these early morning feeding frenzies and to enhance the listener's awareness of the extraordinary polyphony that fills the dawn skies' etc. Henderson was concerned with communicating. Her selection of the sounds presented to her and the sequence of their `appearance' springs from her creative objectives. Whatever form there is flows from that. Although Henderson believes that, in its broadest sense, the symphony has inspired the way in which all the sounds have been put together, she writes in a letter on ABC files: `In the end though, the content dictates the form'.

*Currawong* is the sounds of birds and of their activities: the teaching of their young - claiming of territory - early morning awakening - in human terms, what sounds like gossiping, and feeding from garbage containers. All sounds speak of the open air, and the sounds accompanying the feeding, such as the metallic resonance of garbage tins and lids and the scraping of talons on corrugated iron, invoke a powerful immediacy. The distant calling of birds in the forest behind the feeding area mark out the depth of the sound-stage and go towards defining the total space.
But as much as our understanding and appreciation of *Currawong* may be based on reflections of human behaviour, the listener is not lured into the anthropomorphic trap. Several times during the piece songs and calls fade and we hear, and almost feel, the powerful beating of wings and the rush of air as a bird lands near a microphone. This is an unmistakable message that these birds live in an element that we cannot enter and it does not befit us to consider these sounds, while the birds feed on our scraps, as being produced by some sort of sub-human circus.

Studio Akustische Kunst at West German Radio is an important player in the world of radio sound art and Klaus Schoning of WDR is highly respected by his peers in many countries. That *Currawong* was jointly commissioned by WDR and the ABC is an important event giving a clear indication of the esteem in which the ABC and Moya Henderson are held on the International scene. WDR has broadcast it twice; Schoning refers to it in a personal comment as 'a beautiful piece about these wonderful birds'.

As a matter of interest, Henderson had an early association with Germany, as a scholar in the German Academic Exchange Service. She studied with Maurice Kagel at the Musikhocschule of Cologne from 1974 to 1976.

## References

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